

Digital Safety for College Students • Session 3: Your Footprint: Privacy, Location and the Job Search

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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TO VERIFY

Status: **DRAFT for campus review.** Items in [BRACKETS] are local blanks to fill in. Items marked [VERIFY] need a source check. Items marked [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] need review by the college's counsel, Title IX coordinator or student-affairs leadership before use. This is educational material and is not legal advice.

At a glance

SPECIMEN LABEL	
LENGTH	50 minutes
WHO	Students aged about 17 to 24 in first-year seminars, orientation, student success courses, residence life and clubs. Works for groups of 8 to 40.
TOPICS	Location sharing, what apps collect, data brokers and people-search sites, a clean professional footprint for job and housing applications.
LED BY	A trained facilitator (faculty, staff, peer educator) with a campus counselor or advocate on call for Sessions 5 and 6
MATERIALS	Slides for Session 3; Footprint Audit worksheet, one per student; Scenario cards 3A to 3F; Campus Safety Card; Evaluation card

NO STUDENT ACCOUNTS, NO student data collected, ever. The evaluation card is anonymous.

Objectives

By the end of the session, students can:

- Describe three layers of a digital footprint: what you post, what others post about you, and what is collected about you.
- Review your own location-sharing and app permissions and change at least one.
- Explain what a data broker is and how a person can ask for removal.
- Search your own name the way an employer or landlord might, and decide what to do about what you find.

Before you start (about 20 minutes of prep)

- ☐ Run a search on your own name and a fictional name in a private window so you know what the students will see. Do not search students.
- ☐ Check the current instructions for the two or three people-search sites you intend to mention as examples, or choose to name none and talk about the category. [VERIFY]
- ☐ Note that students at risk from a stalker or abusive partner may have specific reasons to hide where they live. Have the Session 6 resources ready.
- ☐ Read the master disclosure protocol in the Facilitator Guide and the session-specific notes below.
- ☐ Print the Campus Safety Card with local blanks filled in.

Agenda

MINUTES	SEGMENT
0 to 5	Open: who is looking, and why
5 to 13	Location, apps and what gets collected
13 to 21	Data brokers and the job-search footprint
21 to 36	Activity: Footprint Audit (private)
36 to 44	Discussion
44 to 50	Takeaway and evaluation card

Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. In this module the idea has the same four steps for adults. Hackles up is the noticing step: a prickle that something is too good, too urgent, too secret or just a little off. Pause means nothing has to happen in the next five minutes. Check means confirming through a door you opened yourself, such as a known phone number or the official app.

Tell means bringing in a person; a false alarm costs little, and if you were fooled anyway it is never your fault.

Facilitator script

LINES IN THE SCRIPT are written to be said in your own voice. Change the words freely; keep the facts. Items in [BRACKETS] are local.

0 TO 5 MINUTES: OPEN: WHO IS LOOKING, AND WHY

Today is about being in charge of your own information. I am not going to tell you to disappear from the internet. That is not realistic, and you have reasons to be visible, such as friends, a portfolio, a business, a team. The goal is to choose what is visible to whom.

Three layers to keep in mind. First, what you post yourself. Second, what other people post about you: photos, tags, comments, group chats that get screenshot. Third, what is collected about you by apps, websites and data brokers whether or not you ever posted anything. We have different amounts of control over each layer, and I will show you where the levers are.

One rule for the whole session. Audit yourself and nobody else. Please do not look up classmates or ex-partners. Looking up other people is how a tool that can protect you turns into a way to harm somebody.

5 TO 13 MINUTES: LOCATION, APPS AND WHAT GETS COLLECTED

Location. Many apps ask for your location "always." For most, "while using" is enough, and "never" is fine for some. Phones also keep a log of places you visit and let you share your live location with friends. Sharing with friends can be very useful for getting home safely. The trap is leaving it on forever with a long list of people. Set an end time, and review the list each semester. If a partner or a roommate asks you to share your location all the time, we will talk in Session 6 about why that deserves a second thought.

Photos and posts. A picture can show a building, a street sign, a license plate, a room number or a class schedule on a desk. Some services strip location data from photos you upload and some do not [VERIFY for the platforms you use]. A simple habit helps: post after you have left a place, and keep your room number, your schedule and your commute off public posts. The point is to keep strangers from getting a free map.

App permissions. On your phone, open the privacy settings and look at which apps can use location, contacts, camera, microphone and photos. Many students are surprised. Turn off what an app does not need to do its job. Also note your browser's and your phone's advertising settings; they limit some tracking but do not stop it [VERIFY].

13 TO 21 MINUTES: DATA BROKERS AND THE JOB-SEARCH FOOTPRINT

Data brokers are companies that gather information about people from public records, apps and purchases, then sell or lease it. Some run people-search sites where a name brings up an address, a phone number and a list of relatives. Most have a form to request removal. It is slow because there are many of them, and information often reappears, so removal is something you repeat once or twice a year [VERIFY]. Some states give residents extra rights to ask for deletion [VERIFY for your state]. A paid service can do the repeating for you, at a cost and with its own privacy trade-offs, so read before you hand over information [VERIFY].

The job search. Employers and landlords sometimes search applicants' names [VERIFY: practices and legal limits vary]. Open a private window and search your name in quotes, your name plus your college, and your usernames. Ask yourself what a stranger would conclude. Then three practical moves. Take down or hide what you would not want a hiring manager to read, using the platform settings. Ask friends to remove a tagged photo with a short, friendly message. And build one professional profile that is easy to find, so it is the first thing people see. If an old post is embarrassing but ordinary, it often does not matter. You are looking for what could be misread, and what shows your address.

A caution about job offers and your information. A fake recruiter can be a way to collect your Social Security number, address and bank details. Do not hand over that information until you have verified the employer and have an actual offer. That connects back to Session 1.

Activity (15 minutes): Footprint Audit (private)**Set-up**

- Each student works alone with a worksheet and their own phone or a lab computer. Nobody shares what they find.
- Remind the room: only your own name and accounts.

Steps

1. Search your name in a private window, in quotes. Note anything that shows your address, phone number, or a post you would reword today. (4 min)
2. Open your phone's location settings. Count how many apps have "always." Change at least one to "while using" or "never." (3 min)
3. Open your live-location sharing list. Remove one person or set an end time. (2 min)
4. On one social account, check who can see your posts and who can tag you. (3 min)

5. Choose your three actions for the week and write them on the worksheet. Share only the actions, if you want, with a partner. (3 min)

SCENARIO CARDS (PRINT AND CUT; EVERY CARD IS A FICTIONAL COMPOSITE)

Names and details are invented. Any resemblance to a real student is accidental. Change names if one matches a student in your room.

Card 3A The old posts

Rashad is applying for a summer internship. A search shows jokes he posted at 16 that read badly now, and a public photo from a party.

Card 3B Two Pillars

Pilar's name appears next to a different person's profile, with similar details. She worries an employer will mix them up.

Card 3C Room number

Ansel posts a happy picture in front of his residence hall door. The room number is visible, and so is a note that says he is away until Sunday.

Card 3D Forever location

Joon shares live location with fourteen contacts, some of whom he has not spoken to in a year. He set it up freshly last year.

Card 3E My address online

Esperanza finds a people-search page that lists her address and her relatives. She is a single parent who has had a difficult neighbor.

Card 3F A school photo

Walt, a student parent, wants to post a picture of his daughter in her school uniform in front of the school sign.

ROLE-PLAY PRACTICE (NO STUDENT PLAYS A VICTIM OR AN OFFENDER)

The Takedown Request. Pairs. Partner A practices a short, friendly message to a friend asking them to take down a tagged photo: "Hey, that is a fun picture, and I would rather it not be tagged with my name. Could you take it down or change the tag?" Partner B plays the friend and answers kindly: "Of course, done." Then they swap and practice a second line for a friend who says no: "I get it, and I am asking again. If it stays up I will report it to the platform." No one plays someone who refuses harshly.

FACILITATOR KEY

Remind students that the audit is for decisions, not for panic. Most of what they find will be ordinary.

CARD	WHAT TO LISTEN FOR
3A The old posts	Key: review and hide or delete what he would not want read; many old posts are ordinary and do not matter; focus on content that could be misread, and tighten settings. No need to erase his whole presence.
3B Two Pillars	Key: build a clear professional profile with a middle initial or a consistent username; ask the platform or site to correct anything that is wrong; the goal is to make the right profile easy to find.
3C Room number	Key: take it down or crop; share with friends only; avoid posting your room number or when you are away. Frame it as a habit, not as a blame story.
3D Forever location	Key: review the list; use "until" settings; share with a few close people; do a review each semester.
3E My address online	Key: use the site's opt-out form; keep records; repeat periodically; consider other removal services with caution; if she fears harassment, talk with [CAMPUS POLICE] or an advocate about safety planning. Some states have address-confidentiality programs [VERIFY].
3F A school photo	Key: that photo names the school; he decides what to share, and a private group is an option. Keep the discussion on his choices and avoid judging his parenting.

Discussion (8 minutes)

- What surprised you in your audit, if you are willing to say? You can describe it without details.
- What is the difference between sharing your location with a friend for a night and leaving it on indefinitely?
- Who has the right to ask you to share your location or your passwords? How do you say no kindly?
- How do we respect other people's privacy when we post photos from events?

Takeaway (read aloud, then hand out the evaluation card)

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
You cannot control everything about your footprint, and you can control more than you think. Audit yourself, set an end time on location, ask politely for removals, and keep one clean professional profile.	

If a student discloses

TO VERIFY

Never promise confidentiality you cannot give. Title IX responsible-employee duties and campus reporting rules vary by institution and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY current federal rules and state law]. Before the session, find out which category you are in, and say so to students.

Master steps (the same in every session):

1. **Say the heads-up first.** If a student starts to tell you something personal, pause them kindly before the details: "Thank you. Before you go on, I want you to know what I can and cannot keep private. [As a staff member I may have to share some of this with the Title IX office. COUNSEL TO CONFIRM your role.] If you would rather talk with someone who can keep it confidential, I can walk you to [COUNSELING CENTER]." Then let the student choose.
1. **Listen and believe.** Stay calm. "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault." Skip the "why" questions. Let the student use their own words.
1. **Do not investigate.** Ask only what you need to connect them with help: are you safe right now, and what would help most today? Never ask to see images, messages or accounts. Do not contact the other person.
1. **Never promise confidentiality or outcomes you cannot give.** Say what you will do and who you will tell. Responsible-employee duties under Title IX and campus policy vary by institution and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY current federal rules and your state law].
1. **Offer choices.** Counseling, a victim advocate, the Title IX office, campus police, the platform's report form, or none of these today. The student decides what to do next whenever the law and policy allow.
1. **Make a warm handoff.** Offer to walk with them, sit beside them during the call, or help write the email. A phone number on a card is a weaker handoff than a person.
1. **Safety first.** Immediate danger: 911 or campus police. Thoughts of suicide or self-harm: stay with the student, bring in the counseling center or a crisis line, and use 988 (call or text 988) or Crisis Text Line (text HOME to 741741).
1. **If a minor is involved** (an image of someone under 18, or a child at risk), reporting duties may apply to you as an adult, and they differ by state and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY state law]. Do not copy, forward or screenshot such an image. Direct the student to NCMEC's CyberTipline and Take It Down.

1. **Write it down afterward.** Record the student's words and what you said and did, as your policy requires. Share with others only on a need-to-know basis. Talk with your supervisor about what you heard so you are not carrying it alone.

Specific to this session:

- Privacy discussions can surface stalking, harassment or fear of an ex-partner, or a student who is hiding from someone. Do not ask for details. Offer [CAMPUS POLICE], [TITLE IX OFFICE] and [COUNSELING CENTER], and, if the student wishes, a confidential advocate. Hotline: loveisrespect (1-866-331-9474 or text LOVEIS to 22522) [VERIFY].
- If a student says their address or schedule was posted publicly to harass them, treat it as harassment (Session 6) and mention [CAMPUS POLICE] and the platform's report form.
- Do not accept or request a copy of private information in class. If a student pastes their data or someone else's data on a screen, close it and say so kindly.

Accessibility and inclusion notes

For this session:

- Not everyone has a smartphone or private time to do this audit. Provide a paper checklist and a lab computer path.
- Students who are survivors of stalking or domestic violence may have already done a careful audit and may want to talk about advanced steps. Direct them to an advocate and keep the group conversation general.
- Some students do not want to be searched at all (for example, people with safety or immigration worries). Treat the audit as the student's own choice.

For every session:

- **International students.** Scam scripts, institutions and legal systems differ by country, and some scams exploit visa fears. Say plainly that a real college or government office will not demand payment in gift cards, and point to the international student office as a place to check any message about status. Use plain English, avoid idioms, share slides ahead of time, and let students use a translation tool during activities. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM: any reporting duties that apply to international students' status information; do not speculate about immigration consequences in class.]
- **Students with disabilities.** Send slides and cards in advance in accessible formats (the decks are built with real slide titles, reading

order and speaker notes). Use captions for any video. Read cards aloud for anyone who wants that. Allow extra time. Disability services can advise on assistive technology. Do not require anyone to speak, write by hand or move around the room.

- **First-generation students.** Do not assume anyone knows how financial aid, housing contracts or campus offices work. Name the real office and what it does. Describe the normal process before you describe the scam version of it.
- **Students who are parents or caregivers.** Evening and commuter schedules often mean children in the background or a short window to attend. Allow children in the room for lecture portions where the content suits it, and offer the printed cards for take-home. Examples that involve a child's photos or school should be framed around the adult's choices.
- **Commuter and evening students.** Offer a recorded or self-paced version of the same content with the same cards [LOCAL: confirm your platform's accessibility and privacy settings]. Keep sessions on time. Provide the handouts as one page so they fit a bag or a phone screen.
- **Everyone.** Participation is always optional. Offer a Pass card, a written question box, and a clear way to step out and return. Use content notes before heavy material, and show no images of the harms discussed.

Local resource table (fill in before the session)

NEED	WHO	HOW
Immediate danger	911, or [CAMPUS POLICE EMERGENCY NUMBER]	Call
Campus police, non-emergency	[CAMPUS POLICE NON-EMERGENCY NUMBER]	Call or walk in
Campus counseling center	[COUNSELING CENTER NAME, PHONE, LOCATION, HOURS] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM whether it is a confidential resource]	Call or walk in
Title IX office	[TITLE IX COORDINATOR NAME, EMAIL, PHONE] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM how reports are handled]	Email or call
Dean of students or student affairs	[OFFICE, PHONE, LOCATION]	Walk in
Financial aid and bursar	[OFFICE, PHONE, LOCATION]	Walk in or call the number on the college website
IT help desk and security	[HELP DESK PHONE, EMAIL, LOCATION]	Call or walk in
International student office	[OFFICE, PHONE]	Walk in
Disability services	[OFFICE, PHONE]	Walk in
Health center or victim advocate	[NAME, PHONE] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM confidentiality]	Call
Suicide or crisis support	988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988; chat at 988lifeline.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Text-based crisis support	Crisis Text Line	Text HOME to 741741 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Intimate images shared or threatened (you were 18 or older when the image was made)	StopNCII.org	stopncii.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Intimate images made when you were under 18	NCMEC Take It Down	takeitdown.ncmec.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Sextortion, or any image of someone under 18	NCMEC CyberTipline	report.cybertip.org or 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Blackmail and internet crime	FBI IC3	ic3.gov [VERIFY]
Scams and fraud	FTC	reportfraud.ftc.gov [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Identity theft	FTC	identitytheft.gov [VERIFY]
Dating abuse and controlling relationships	loveisrespect	Call 1-866-331-9474 or text LOVEIS to 22522; loveisrespect.org [VERIFY before printing]

RE-VERIFY EVERY NUMBER AND address before printing. Hotline details marked VERIFIED were checked in the Hackles verification rounds dated 2026-10-05 and should still be re-checked before any print run.

Evaluation card (anonymous; print four per page)

Evaluation cards are anonymous. Do not collect names, student ID numbers or email addresses. Tally counts only (for example, how many students circled each number). Aggregate results can go to your supervisor; individual cards are recycled after tallying [LOCAL: confirm records policy].

Session 3: Privacy, data brokers and your digital footprint

- I feel more able to spot a problem like the ones we discussed today. (1 = not at all, 5 = very much) 1 2 3 4 5
- I know where on campus I could go for help with this topic. (1 = not at all, 5 = very much) 1 2 3 4 5
- The first thing I will change in my settings this week is: _____
- What would make this session better?
- Anything you want the facilitator to know? (Do not include names or personal details.)

Facilitator reflection (after the session, for your own notes)

- What went well? What would I change in the timing?
- Which card sparked the best discussion?
- Did a student disclose? Did I follow the protocol and write it down? Who did I debrief with?
- Which local blanks still need filling in?

Sources and verification notes

- How platforms handle photo location data. [VERIFY]
- Opt-out processes and recurrence for data brokers. [VERIFY]
- State deletion rights and address-confidentiality programs. [VERIFY]
- Employer and landlord search practices and legal limits. [VERIFY]
- Paid removal services and their privacy trade-offs. [VERIFY]
- Hotline and reporting details are taken from the Hackles verification files (kit/16_Verification) and the 9-12 Teacher Guide appendix C1. Re-check before printing.
- Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled study. It does not replace campus counseling, Title IX processes, legal advice or emergency services.

